First Name Data From the 2020 Census

2020 Census Briefs

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INTRODUCTION

Frequently Occurring First Names in the 2020 Census is the second U.S. Census Bureau data product listing the most common first names reported in the decennial census. The previous data release, after the 1990 Census, was based on results from the post-enumeration survey rather than the census itself (U.S. Census Bureau, 1995). This 2020 product is derived from the 2020 Census results, using methods developed for last name review since 2000. The 2000 methodology was revised for the 2010 last name product (Comenetz, 2016) and further revised for 2020. This document first summarizes the methodological changes between 2010 and 2020, then describes the 2020 results and compares them with data from previous decades.[1]

[1] This brief describes the overall frequency of first names, as well as some of the basic demographic characteristics that are associated with first names. The presentation of data in this brief focuses on summarized aggregates of counts and characteristics associated with names, and the data do not in any way identify specific individuals. Data on first and last names are always tabulated separately.

Names data tables provide data on the frequency of individual names. They are not suitable for producing aggregate statistics such as the total U.S. population of a given race or Hispanic origin group. Names data are subject to error arising from nonresponse.

The public first name data tables include more than 53,000 first names with a frequency of 100 or more in the 2020 Census. Subsets of the full tables, with the top 1,000 most frequent first names, are also available.

The term "predominantly" is used where the majority of the people with the listed names identified with a single race, Hispanic origin, or sex category. For example, "Jose" is a predominantly Hispanic first name because 96 percent of the people named Jose chose Hispanic in their response to the 2020 Census.

The Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data used to produce this product. Disclosure Review Board (DRB) approval number: CBDRB-FY26-058.

This brief is released to inform interested parties of ongoing research and to encourage discussion of work in progress. Any views expressed are those of the author and not necessarily those of the U.S. Census Bureau.

METHODOLOGY

The 2020 first and last name projects used the programming and methods from the 2010 last name project as a starting point. Edits and corrections from last name processing in 2000 and 2010 were also applied to 2020 first names—many of the same quality issues affect both first and last names. Names data from each census contain different quality issues, and an extensive review led to an expansion of the set of edits and corrections. This section includes a description of ways in which the 2020 methods differed from the previous methodology that is described in Word et al. (2007) and Comenetz (2016).

The 2020, 2010, and 2000 names products use the same six Hispanic origin and race categories: Non-Hispanic White alone, Non-Hispanic Black or African American alone, Non-Hispanic American Indian and Alaska Native alone, Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone, Non-Hispanic Two or More Races, and Hispanic or Latino origin.[2]

Creation of the 2020 product started with raw data from the 2020 Census—the first names provided by census respondents—and the set of edits applied to last names from the 2010 Census. The raw 2020 names list was extensively reviewed by a group of

[2] In the rest of this brief, White is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic White alone; Black is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic Black or African American alone; Hispanic is used interchangeably with Hispanic or Latino origin; Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone.

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Census Bureau staff. The most time-consuming review was manual ("eyeball") scanning of first names with a frequency of 5 or more, about 710,000 names. Team findings were consolidated into a new set of edits, comprising updates or corrections needed to fix problems that arose in 2020 but not in 2010, or to fix problems that were partially addressed in the 2010 programming but were more widespread or complex in the 2020 dataset, or to address problems unique to first names rather than last names. New programming, to add to the 2010 programs, was written to implement the new set of edits. Revised output was checked to determine if all edits were successfully addressed, and also compared with the 1990 product to determine if changes in name frequency (name count, or number of times each name was reported in the census) over the decade tracked general demographic trends.

Programming and reviews provided a more accurate first name dataset, edited for consistency and omitting nonname text (examples provided in the next paragraph). Two further edits were applied to ensure the confidentiality of individual census data in the public names tables. First, the 2020 first names data were limited to names also found in the 2010 Census that had a frequency of at least 100 in both years. Because there was no public 2010 first name product, first name frequencies were calculated from the nonpublic 2010 individual census responses. Second, the data entered the Census Bureau's disclosure avoidance process for noise infusion. Noise was infused separately into the race and Hispanic origin and sex data. Total counts (total name frequencies) and proportions were calculated from noisy race and Hispanic origin or sex data; noise was not separately infused into the calculated data. For first names, the total counts calculated from race and Hispanic origin and sex exhibit discrepancies because noise was infused independently into each dataset.

The noise added to the counts of first name by race and Hispanic origin has at least a 95 percent probability of falling between ± 3. For example, if the true 2020 Census count of people of Hispanic origin named SAMPLENAME is 1,000, then there is at least a 95 percent chance that the noise-infused value appearing in the public first name table will be between 997 and 1,003. For first name by sex data, the added noise has at least a 95 percent probability of falling between ± 4. Therefore, noise infusion should have a small relative effect on the vast majority of name counts in this table. Also, because of noise infusion, the public names tables contain a few names with total frequencies below 100, that is, where the sum of noise-infused race and Hispanic origin counts ended up under 100.

After noise infusion, an optimization procedure was applied to ensure no negative counts would appear in the final data. However, the original noisy data, including negative counts, are also available for research purposes.

2020 and Previous Edits

Processing of 2020 Census names data incorporated all edits and deletions applied in 2010 and 2000 (Comenetz, 2016). These edits included removal of all punctuation marks, numbers, and spaces; deletion of suffixes such as JR, SR, III, and THIRD; and correction of some obvious spelling errors in common names. Therefore, MICHAEL, MI CH AEL, MICHAELJR, and MICHAEL III are all counted as MICHAEL.

Deletions carried over from 2010 included single-letter entries, most two-letter entries, and many obvious nonnames such as ABCDEFG, ADULT FEMALE, DONT KNOW, and NO NOMBRE. Names that looked improbable but not impossible were kept, e.g., ANONYMOUS.

The primary problem identified by reviewers in the raw 2020 data was a huge increase in the number of generic words (e.g., PERSON) and number words (TWENTY-TWO) listed as names or parts of name entries. Most review and programming effort was devoted to finding and deleting generic word entries, and modifying entries that included both an actual name and generic words.

Reviewers also noted that in Spanish names containing Ñ, the Ñ was converted to ?. For example, PEÑA became PE?A. Any symbols other than the standard 26 English letters are omitted in the names tables, so in these cases, ? was corrected to N—becoming PENA in this example.

Generic and Nonname Edits

Over 10 million first name entries in the raw 2020 Census results either consisted of generic words or included generic words along with an actual name. If not removed or edited, several generic words, such as PERSON, would have been among the highest-frequency names shown in the final products.

Besides PERSON, generic words most commonly described family status (CHILD, DAUGHTER, GRANDSON), personal characteristics (ELDERLY, FEMALE, MALE, SINGLE, STUDENT), and residential status (RESIDENT, TENANT, HOUSEHOLDER). Some name entries combined generic terms and real names, as in MRS SMITH.

Another large category of generic entries were those containing numbers spelled out as words, or generic terms combined with numbers. Examples include EIGHTEEN, TWENTY-TWO, CHILD 2, PERSON FIVE, and PERSONA DOS.

Removal of generic terms is inherently imperfect because some generic terms are also real first or last names—for example, BABY, CHILD, PERSON, SON, and YOUNG. In ambiguous cases, names were left unedited. Also, some words were considered generic if they appeared as a first name but not as a last name, or vice versa. For example, CHILD was a very common generic first name entry, is rarely a real first name, but is also a common real last name. This determination was supported in some cases by reference to the Social Security Administration's baby name counts covering the past century (Social Security Administration, 2025).

Many entries containing versions of JOHN DOE and JANE DOE were deleted from the names datasets. Simple entries with JOHN or JANE as the first name and DOE as the last name were not deleted because these can be real names. Therefore, the frequency of DOE listed in the last name table is surely too high. However, the DOE frequency was greatly reduced by the deletion of any entry that was clearly generic, such as JOHN DOE #2, DOE 4, and BABY DOE.

In addition to generics, over 700 nonname words or word combinations were added to the delete list. These included, for example, several misspellings of UNKNOWN.

Time and budget limitations also prevented manual review of every name. Therefore, the final name tables do contain some generic and nonname terms, and counts of real names that can also be generic may be inflated—especially where, as with PERSON, the generic term was common in 2020 results. Nevertheless, results suggest that edit procedures eliminated the vast majority (more than 95 percent) of nonname entries.

SUMMARY OF RESULTS

Table 1 outlines the national distribution of first names by frequency in the United States in the 2020 Census. The unedited census results contained about 6.0 million unique first names reported by census respondents in 2020. Editing removed about 800,000 of these, and revised millions more as described in this brief, leaving 5.2 million different first names. Of these, 25 were reported more than 1 million times each, while over 5 million, or 99 percent, were reported fewer than 100 times. Many of the latter were unique first names or unique variations of more frequent names, including errors resulting from the transcription of names handwritten on census forms. After editing, first names were recorded for 302 million people, or 91.1 percent of the population enumerated in the 2020 Census.

The public first name data tables provide frequency, rank, and distribution by Hispanic origin, race groups, and sex. The top five first names in 2020 were all predominantly male: MICHAEL, JOHN, JAMES, DAVID, and ROBERT.

The next two tables look only at the 1,000 most frequent first names. Table 2 shows the ten names with the highest shares of identification with each Hispanic origin or race group. For example, 98.5 percent of people with the name GUADALUPE are Hispanic.

Table 1.
First Names by Frequency Range and Number of People: 2020

Frequency range	First names			People with these first names		
	Number	Cumulative number	Cumulative proportion (percent)	Number	Cumulative number	Cumulative proportion (percent)
1,000,000+	25	25	0.0	42,561,488	42,561,488	14.1
100,000–999,999	524	549	0.0	139,268,200	181,829,688	60.2
10,000–99,999	1919	2,468	0.0	59,451,794	241,281,482	79.9
1,000–9,999	9979	12,447	0.2	28,345,900	269,627,382	89.3
100–999	40,971	53,418	1.0	13,588,072	283,215,454	93.8
1–99	5,163,105	5,216,523	100.0	18,813,873	302,029,327	100.0

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Table 2.

First Names With the Largest Share in Each Hispanic Origin and Race Group: 2020

First name	Rank among all first names	Frequency	Occurrences per 100,000 people	Percent in this group
Non-Hispanic White Alone				
BETH	417	136,268	45.1	95.0
JILL	285	194,542	64.4	93.7
SCOTT	59	655,955	217.2	93.2
DOUG	896	50,323	16.7	92.8
KATHLEEN	77	547,317	181.2	92.7
COLLEEN	412	137,520	45.5	92.7
LYNNE	847	54,520	18.1	92.4
JODI	715	71,742	23.8	92.3
BRETT	397	142,068	47.0	91.7
SUZANNE	295	188,917	62.5	91.7
Non-Hispanic Black or African American Alone				
TYRONE	894	50,648	16.8	81.7
WILLIE	358	156,150	51.7	79.9
REGINALD	740	68,887	22.8	77.9
MAURICE	718	71,282	23.6	60.0
TERRANCE	886	51,101	16.9	56.0
DERRICK	509	110,566	36.6	54.6
JADA	822	57,492	19.0	54.5
ANDRE	512	110,187	36.5	54.3
DOMINIQUE	787	62,490	20.7	54.3
KELVIN	991	43,448	14.4	50.9
Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander Alone				
MOHAMMAD	873	51,752	17.1	56.9
MOHAMMED	930	48,042	15.9	47.9
SON	994	43,269	14.3	24.7
ANDY	582	91,634	30.3	21.0
JENNY	503	111,783	37.0	20.7
KENNY	875	51,663	17.1	16.4
KAI	858	53,210	17.6	15.9
FATIMA	861	52,706	17.5	14.7
ANNIE	487	115,895	38.4	13.5
ALI	735	69,300	22.9	13.0
Non-Hispanic American Indian and Alaska Native Alone				
CHEYENNE	805	59,826	19.8	3.2
DAKOTA	543	102,679	34.0	2.5
VERNON	828	56,774	18.8	2.0
HARLEY	980	43,970	14.6	1.9
DONOVAN	903	49,792	16.5	1.8
MISTY	726	70,426	23.3	1.8
NEVAEH	803	60,294	20.0	1.7
LENA	883	51,226	17.0	1.7
ARNOLD	940	47,510	15.7	1.7
CHANCE	998	43,134	14.3	1.7
Non-Hispanic Two or More Races				
KAI	858	53,210	17.6	19.5
AALIYAH	737	69,237	22.9	12.3
NEVAEH	803	60,294	20.0	12.0
MYA	889	51,023	16.9	11.3
MAYA	542	102,998	34.1	11.2
ARIA	856	53,370	17.7	10.6
ISAIAH	315	175,786	58.2	10.4
JADA	822	57,492	19.0	10.1
ELIJAH	216	252,755	83.7	9.6
DONOVAN	903	49,792	16.5	9.4

Notes available at end of table.

Table 2.
First Names With the Largest Share in Each Hispanic Origin and Race Group: 2020—Con.

First name	Rank among all first names	Frequency	Occurrences per 100,000 people	Percent in this group
Hispanic or Latino Origin				
GUADALUPE	441	128,245	42.5	98.5
BLANCA	584	91,172	30.2	98.4
MAYRA	764	65,661	21.7	97.8
YESENIA	904	49,769	16.5	97.8
JUANA	597	88,953	29.5	97.3
JESUS	150	331,350	109.7	97.3
ALEJANDRA	673	78,499	26.0	97.3
MARISOL	909	49,541	16.4	96.8
GUILLERMO	794	61,840	20.5	96.8
HECTOR	330	168,415	55.8	96.7

Note: Table limited to first names that were among the top 1,000 by total frequency in 2020.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

There is little overlap among the six lists, highlighting the degree to which first names vary among racial and ethnic groups in the United States.

Most individual first names do not reflect the diversity of the population as a whole. In many cases, over 90 percent of people reporting a name identify with just one of the six Hispanic origin or race groups. In contrast, few first names are equally common in multiple Hispanic origin or race groups.

Tables 3 and 4 illustrate the even greater division between predominantly male and predominantly female names. Many first names are more than 99 percent male or female; few names are equally common among men and women.

Table 3.
First Names With the Largest Share That Were Male and Female: 2020

First name	Rank among all first names	Frequency	Occurrences per 100,000 people	Percent in this group
Male				
KURT	693	74,867	24.8	99.9
JEFFREY	46	735,428	243.5	99.9
STEVEN	27	972,808	322.1	99.9
RONALD	52	689,843	228.4	99.9
RICHARD	11	1,575,998	521.8	99.9
PHILIP	250	223,037	73.8	99.9
TIMOTHY	38	802,946	265.8	99.9
DAVID	4	2,813,017	931.4	99.9
DOUGLAS	122	383,164	126.9	99.9
MATTHEW	15	1,315,151	435.4	99.9
Female				
KATHLEEN	77	547,321	181.2	99.9
SUZANNE	295	188,910	62.5	99.9
GRETCHEN	972	44,623	14.8	99.9
LYNDA	770	64,728	21.4	99.9
SUSAN	26	979,771	324.4	99.9
PAMELA	88	495,991	164.2	99.9
SHERRI	722	70,746	23.4	99.9
DEBORAH	66	622,217	206.0	99.9
DEBRA	98	465,857	154.2	99.9
HEATHER	94	473,464	156.8	99.9

Note: Table limited to first names that were among the top 1,000 by total frequency in 2020.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

For the population as a whole in 2020, the 10 most frequent first names accounted for 8.0 percent of the population (Table 5), while to cover one-quarter of the total population required just 69 first names. The frequencies of the most common American first names are higher than their counterparts among last names.

The White and Hispanic populations are less diverse than the national average in this respect, perhaps reflecting the use of one main linguistic pool for name selection in each case—English and Spanish. In contrast, the Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander population has the lowest level of first name clustering, combining the effects of a high share of foreign-born population and diverse linguistic origins.

The female population has much more first-name diversity than the male population—16 percent of men have one of the ten most frequent names among men, while only 7.8 percent of women have one of the top ten names (Table 6). Compared to men, almost three times as many names are needed to cover 25 percent of the female population. This is reflected in the overall first name ranking, where eight of the top ten most common first names in the United States are predominantly male, even though women outnumber men nationally.

Table 4.
First Names Where the Male and Female Shares Were Most Equal: 2020

First name	Rank among all first names	Frequency	Male (percent)	Female (percent)
Least Difference Between Male and Female Shares				
HARLEY	980	43,968	49.2	50.8
EMERSON	990	43,461	48.8	51.2
QUINN	758	66,536	47.5	52.5
KERRY	631	83,556	45.9	54.1
JESSIE	537	104,536	43.8	56.2
RILEY	291	191,103	43.6	56.4
CASEY	334	165,300	57.3	42.7
SKYLER	833	56,083	60.3	39.7
PEYTON	495	113,474	39.2	60.8
SIDNEY	852	53,874	61.8	38.2

Note: Table limited to first names that were among the top 1,000 by total frequency in 2020.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Table 5.
First Name Clustering by Hispanic Origin and Race Groups: 2020

Group	Group covered by top ten first names (percent)	First names needed to cover 25 percent of group (number)
Total population	8.0	69
White alone	10.7	44
Black alone	5.4	139
American Indian and Alaska Native alone	6.3	104
Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone	2.7	315
Two or More Races	6.4	89
Hispanic or Latino origin	10.3	59

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Table 6.
First Name Clustering by Sex: 2020

Group	Group covered by top 10 first names (percent)	First names needed to cover 25 percent of group (number)
Total population	8.0	69
Male	16.0	22
Female	7.8	58

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

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